

The Adventure

By Jayant Narlikar

This fictional narrative by Jayant Narlikar belongs to the genre of science fiction and deals with the much intriguing aspect of time. The protagonist of this story, Professor Gaitonde, a historian is preparing for his thousandth presidential address in which he would speak on the topic "What course history would have taken if the result of the Battle of Panipat had gone the other way?"

While on an evening stroll he is hit by a truck.

- At that time he was thinking of the catastrophe theory and its implications for history.
- He found himself in another Bombay-which looked more like England (cleaner, big English shops).
- The East India Company was flourishing. In this different Bombay, he went to the Asiatic Society library in the town hall, to read some History books, including the ones he had written.
- Most of the history was as he knew it in his world-but the point where history had changed was the Battle of Panipat. In this different world, the Marathas had won.
- The Marathas had not allowed the East India Company to expand. In fact, its influence was limited to a few places like Bombay, Calcutta and Madras. India had become a democracy but allowed the British to carry on for

commercial reasons.

- Prof. Gaitonde wanted to find out how the Marathas had won the battle. According to one history book, the Maratha army's morale was boosted when Vishwasrao managed to escape death narrowly.

Next morning he went for a stroll to Azad Maidan.

- There was a lecture and Prof. Gaitonde went and sat on the vacant presidential chair.
- It turned out that in this world people were fed up of long speeches and had abolished the 'chairing' custom.
- They got angry because Prof. Gaitonde would not stop talking. They threw things at him and then got onto the stage to throw him out. Suddenly Prof Gaitonde vanished.
- He was found in the Azad Maidan in his own familiar world. But where had he been for two days remained a mystery.?
- He showed Rajender Deshpande the proof that he had been somewhere else and not just imagining things- the torn-off page of the history book from the other world, about Vishwasrao escaping death.

Q.1 Who was Professor Gaitonde? What was his plan in Bombay?

Professor Gaitonde was a historian. He had written five volumes on History. He was on his way to Bombay. He planned to go to a library and consult the history books there to find out how the present state of affairs was reached.

Q.2 What were the things that Professor Gaitonde noticed as the train entered the British Raj territory?

As the train touched Sarhad, From where the British Raj began, an Anglo- Indian in uniform went through the train checking permits. The blue carriages of the train carried the letters GBMR on the side an acronym for 'Greater Bombay Metropolitan Railway'. There was the tiny Union Jack painted on each carriage as a reminder that they were in British territory. As the train stopped at its destination, Victoria Terminus, the station looked remarkably neat and clean. The staff was mostly made up of Anglo-Indians and Parsees with a handful of British officers.

Q3. Where was Khan Sahib going? How did he intend to reach there?

Khan Sahib was going to Peshawar. After the train reached Victoria Terminus he would take the Frontier Mail out of Central, -the same night. From Bombay he would go to Delhi, then to Lahore and then Peshawar. It would be a long journey and he would reach Peshawar two days later.

Q4.What was the strange reality that Professor Gaitonde saw as he stepped out of the station?

As Professor Gaitonde came out of the station, he saw an impressive building. The letters on it revealed that it was the East India headquarters of the East India Company. He was shocked as it was supposed to have had stopped operation soon after the events of 1857 but here it was flourishing.

Q.5. Why did professor Gaitonde enter the Forbes building?
What was his experience there?

Ans. The professor went to Forbes building to meet Vinaya Gaitonde, his own son. The receptionist searched through the directory of employees. But there was no person bearing that name. It was a big blow. He felt that so far everything had been shocking so the non-existence of his son was not totally unexpected.

Q.6. What did the professor do in the Town Hall Library?
The professor consulted the history books that he himself had written. There was no change in the events upto death of Aurangzeb. The change had occurred in last volume. He read the description of the battle of Panipat. Abdali was defeated by Maratha army led by Sadashivrao Bhau and his nephew, Vishwasrao. It established the supremacy of the Marathas. They set up their science research centres. They accepted the help of English experts.

Q.7. Why did Gangadhar Pant go to the Town Hall Library?
What books did he browse? What did he discover?
Gangadhar was witnessing a changed India. He wanted to know the reason. So he went to the Town Hall Library. There he asked for a list of history book including his own. When he got the five volumes, he started looking through them from the beginning. The four volumes seemed to be same as he had written them. However in the last (fifth) volume, history had taken a different turn during the Battle of Panipat. The book mentioned that the Marathas won it handsomely and Abdali was chased back to Kabul by the

triumphant Maratha army led by Sadashivrao Bhau and his nephew, the young Vishwasrao.

Q8. What did the professor wish to find out in history books? He wished to find the answer to his question how Marathas won the Battle of Panipat. He found a clue in a magazine titled Bakhars. Vishwasrao had a narrow escape from being killed by the bullet that brushed past his ear. This boosted the morale of Maratha army and they won the battle.

Q9. 'Victories change future'. How did the victory of the Peshwas in the Battle of Panipat help them?

The victory in the battle was not only successful in building their confidence tremendously but it also established the supremacy of the Marathas in northern India. The East India Company, watching these events temporarily deferred its plan to spread out further. For the Peshwas the immediate result was that the influence of Bhausaheb and Vishwasrao had to retire from state politics.

Q10. Did the victory of the Peshwas cause any effect on the alternate reality which Gangadhar visited?

Yes, it completely changed the chain of events. The East India Company was alarmed when the new Maratha ruler, Vishwasrao, and his brother, Madhavrao, expanded their influence all over India. The Company was limited to pockets of

influence near Bombay, Calcutta and Madras. However, in the nineteenth century the Marathas were aware of the importance of the technological age starting in Europe.

Hence when they set up their own centres for science and technology. The East India Company saw another chance to extend its influence. It offered support and experts. But they were accepted only to make the local centres self-sufficient.

